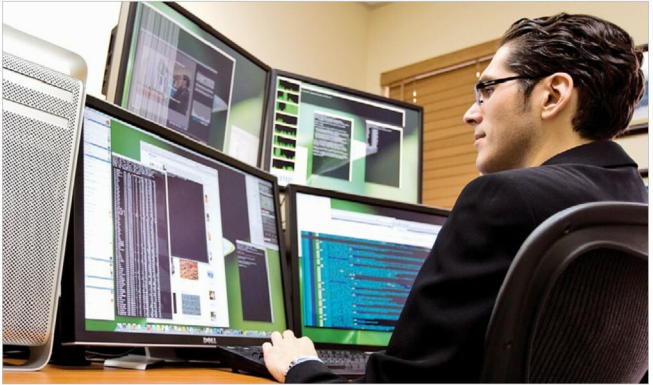


Linux System Administration: Managing Users and Groups

This is an article that takes the reader back to the basics of Linux. It covers the various aspects of users and groups in Linux, like adding or removing them, giving them passwords, etc—all from a systems administrator's point of view.



Linux is a multi-user operating system, which means that more than one user can use Linux at the same time.

Linux provides a beautiful mechanism to manage users in a system. One of the most important roles of a system administrator is to manage the users and groups in a system. All the commands used in this article are explained using the CentOS Linux distro.

Linux user

A user or account of a system is uniquely identified by a numerical number called the UID (unique identification number). There are two types of users – the root or super user and normal users. A root or super user can access all the files, while the normal user has limited access to files. A super user can add, delete and modify a user account. The full account information is stored in the `/etc/passwd` file and a hash password is stored in the file `/etc/shadow`. Some operations on a user account are discussed below.

Creating a user with a default setting: A user can be added by running the `useradd` command at the command

prompt. After creating the user, set a password using the `passwd` utility, as follows:

```
[root@localhost bhargab]# useradd anirban
[root@localhost bhargab]# passwd anirban
Changing password for user anirban.
New password:
Retype new password:
passwd: all authentication tokens updated successfully.
```

The system automatically assigns a UID, creates the home directory (`/home/<username>`) and sets the default shell to `/bin/bash`. The `useradd` command creates a user private group whenever a new user is added to the system and names the group after the user.

Specifying a user's full name when creating a user: A systems administrator can use the `-c` option with `useradd` to specify the user's full name, as shown below:

```
[root@localhost bhargab]# useradd -c "Anirban Choudhury" anirban
```